

BEFORE THE FIRST PAGE

The Star Called Suhail

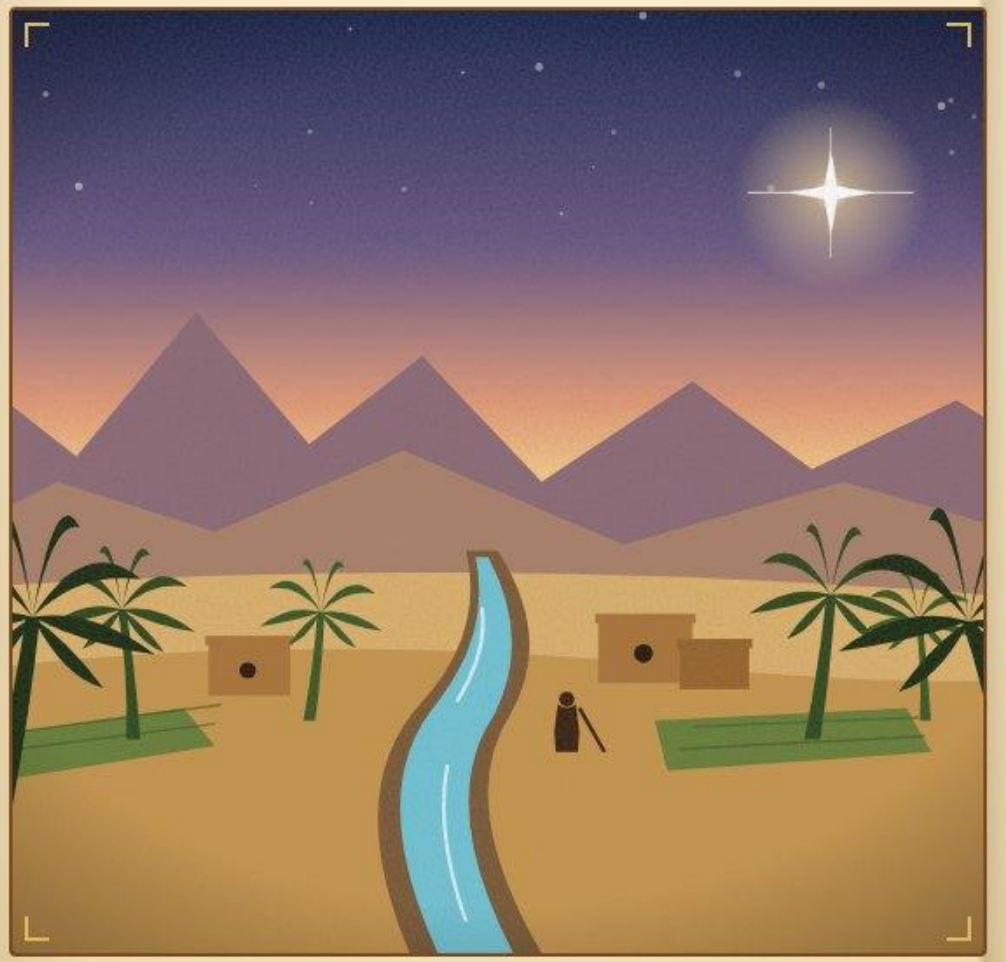
نجم سهيل

Every year, at the end of August, a star climbs over the southern edge of Arabia just before dawn. Its name is Suhail. People here have always watched for it. When Suhail rises, the worst of the summer is over, the nights turn kind, and the pearl divers come home. Pilgrims and sailors found their way by it. Farmers counted their year from it. This book follows that one star across twenty-five centuries, and the people who kept looking up.

في أواخر أغسطس يطلع سهيل قبيل الفجر، فيعرف أهل الجزيرة أن القيظ قد انكسر. هذه حكاية نجم واحد، وأناسٍ لم يكفّوا عن النظر إلى السماء.

You are the founder of one small town. You will lead it through seven ages. Rawi, the storyteller, walks beside you.

▸ Draft text · sources



AGE I · ABOUT 500 BCE TO 630 CE

The Age of Oases

عصر الواحات

Water first. Around three thousand years ago, people in the oases of Al Ain cut gently sloping tunnels underground to lead water to their fields, with nothing but gravity to move it. They called the channel a falaj. Where it surfaced, palms grew, and under the palms, everything else. Some of those channels still feed the same gardens today. At Mleiha, in today's Sharjah, a trading town struck its own silver coins. The desert was never empty. It was engineered.

قبل نحو ثلاثة آلاف عام شقّ أهل العين الأفلاج. فجرى الماء تحت الأرض إلى النخيل. وفي مليحة ضُربت نقود من فضة. لم تكن الصحراء خالية قط.

In the game: every building needs water. Where you dig, and what you place beside the channel, comes first.

▸ Draft text · sources



AGE II · ABOUT 630 TO 800

The Age of Faith and Law

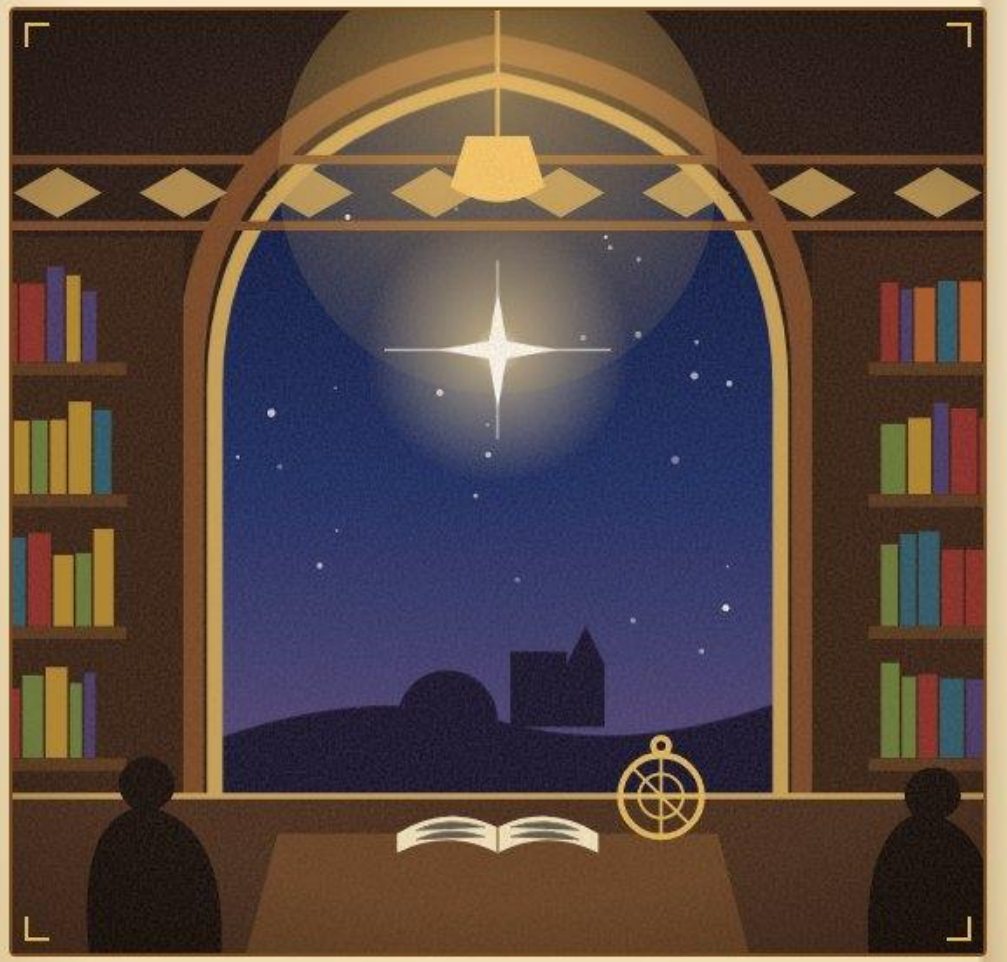
عصر الإيمان والقانون

Around the year 630, Islam reached the towns of south-eastern Arabia. With it came a shared faith, a shared law, and Arabic as the common language of government and learning. A merchant could now make a contract in one city and rely on it in another. The mosque became the centre of town life. Charitable endowments paid for wells, schools and guest houses, so a traveller on the road could expect water and a roof.

نحو سنة ٦٣٠ للميلاد بلغ الإسلام جنوب شرق الجزيرة، فاجتمع الناس على إيمان واحد وقانون واحد ولسان عربي واحد، وصار المسجد قلب المدينة.

In the game: this age is told through what it built, the mosque, the judge's court, the endowed well. No prophet, companion or caliph ever appears as a character.

▸ Draft text · sources



AGE III · ABOUT 800 TO 1250

The Age of Wisdom

عصر الحكمة

In Baghdad, a scholar named al-Khwarizmi wrote a book on solving equations. Its title gave the world the word algebra. His own name became the word algorithm. Every phone, including the one in your hand, runs on an idea with an Arabic name. In the libraries of that age, scholars gathered the learning of Greece, Persia and India, translated it, tested it, and carried it further. None of it was free. Someone chose to pay for knowledge.

في بغداد كتب الخوارزمي كتابه في الجبر، فأعطى العالم كلمتين: الجبر والخوارزمية. كل هاتف اليوم يعمل بفكرة تحمل اسماً عربياً.

In the game: research now gives bonuses that last for ever. Invest early and your town speeds up for the rest of the story.

▸ Draft text · sources



AGE IV · ABOUT 1250 TO 1650

The Age of Sails

عصر الأشرعة

The Indian Ocean was the busiest long-distance trade road in the world, and it ran on the monsoon. Out with one wind, home with the next. Miss the season and you waited months. From Julfar, in today's Ras Al Khaimah, came Ahmad ibn Majid, a navigator who wrote down what the sea had taught him, stars, winds, coasts and harbours, in sailing guides that pilots used for generations. He is remembered as the Lion of the Sea.

كان المحيط الهندي طريق التجارة الأكبر، ورياح الموسم دليله. ومن جلفار خرج أحمد بن ماجد، أسد البحار، فدوّن علم البحر للربابنة من بعده.

In the game: ports, ships and sailing seasons. Timing a voyage is worth as much as choosing it.

▸ Draft text · sources



AGE V · ABOUT 1650 TO 1929

The Age of Pearls

عصر اللؤلؤ

Each summer, for about four months, the boats left for the pearl banks in what was called the great dive. A diver went down on a weighted rope with a clip on his nose, and came up on the strength of the hauler above him. On deck the nahham sang to keep the crew pulling as one. It was hard and dangerous work, and debt followed many men home. Then, at the end of August, Suhail rose. The season was over. The fleet turned for shore.

كل صيف يخرج الغاصة إلى المغاصات في الغوص الكبير، والنهّام يغنّي ليشدّ عزم البحّارة. فإذا طلع سهيل انتهى الموسم وعادت السفن إلى الديار.

This is where your story begins. You found a pearling town on this coast, send out its boats, and decide what the catch is for.

▸ Draft text · sources



AGE VI · ABOUT 1930 TO 1966

The Age of Oil

عصر النفط

Then the pearls stopped paying. A world depression and cultured pearls from Japan broke the market, and the coast fell on hard years. People held on. In 1958 a drilling rig working over an old pearl bank near Das Island struck oil. In July 1962 the first tanker sailed from Abu Dhabi. The sea that had fed this coast with pearls for thousands of years had one more thing to give.

كسدت تجارة اللؤلؤ بالكساد العالمي واللؤلؤ الياباني المستزرع، فصبر أهل الساحل. وفي يوليو ١٩٦٢ أبحرت أول ناقلة نفط من أبوظبي.

In the game: your main income disappears overnight. You rebuild with very little, and so do your rivals.

▸ Draft text · sources



AGE VII · 1968 TO 1971

The Age of Union

عصر الاتحاد

In January 1968 Britain announced it would leave the Gulf by the end of 1971. The small states of the coast had under four years to decide who they would be. They talked, disagreed, and talked again. On 2 December 1971 six emirates raised one flag as the United Arab Emirates. Ras Al Khaimah joined in February 1972, and six became seven. A coast of pearling towns had become a country.

في الثاني من ديسمبر ١٩٧١ رفعت ستّ إمارات علماً واحداً. ثم انضمّت رأس الخيمة في فبراير ١٩٧٢، فاكتمل الاتحاد سبعاً.

In the game: everything you built across six ages is tested. You choose how your town's story ends.

▸ Draft text · sources



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Your Turn

دورك الآن

Channel diggers. Judges and teachers. Scholars, navigators, divers, and the ones who signed. None of them knew how their age would end. They built anyway. Suhail still rises every August over the same coast. Tonight it rises over a small camp with one well and no name yet. That part is yours.

حفّارو الأفلاج، والقضاة والمعلّمون، والعلماء والربابنة
والغاصة... كلّهم بنوا ولم يعرفوا كيف ينتهي عصرهم.
وسهيل ما زال يطلع كل عام. الآن دورك.

How to play: build, collect what your buildings make, send boats out, and answer Rawi's questions. He will show you each step.

▸ Draft text · sources